

The Intelligent Guide to Business Intelligence

Understanding and Buying Business Intelligence Solutions

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When should you read this guide?

While there is still time to change what your business isn't doing right.

Yesterday.

Why?

Because bad information costs U.S. businesses up to \$600 billion a year, according to The Data Warehousing Institute.

That's huge in any economy. Catastrophic in a tight one.

To make things worse, people don't see bad information as the cause of their costly decisions. And things get even more expensive when incorrect data leads to more flawed decisions, more wasted resources, and even more disgruntled shareholders.

By the way, bad information doesn't just mean inaccurate. It means anything you can't understand, or use.

Like the dizzying sea of customer and market data that keeps thousands of analysts working around the clock tweaking spreadsheets to turn millions of numbers gathered from tens of thousands of databases into more spreadsheets that realistically, only 12 people in the world might understand.

So what do you do?

How do you turn thousands of daily customer interactions into something meaningful for the reasonably intelligent people who need to make intelligent business decisions?

The simple answer is to buy a business intelligence solution.

If only buying it intelligently was simple.

Actually, it is. The hard part is getting honest answers to your straightforward questions.

What exactly is business intelligence?

First, business intelligence is not an oxymoron.

Business intelligence is another name for business analytics (or decision support), which have been around for years. It uses numbers such as bookings, revenue, and employee retention, to report on how your business is doing.

It helps you answer the most difficult questions in business:

1. What did I do right today?
2. What did I do wrong today?
3. And when will I know?

However, that information needs to get to you in time to actually do something about it (aside from saying "oops"). Preferably, in real time.

Or as most people call it, *live*. And presented in a way you can understand.

This process usually involves one or more analysts pulling data from your company's data sources (whether you call them data warehouses, data marts, or databases), cleaning up the data, translating it, running calculations on it, summarizing the results, selecting what is useful, creating reports that make sense, and distributing the reports to people who desperately need them.

These reports should help you see how things are connected and interrelated. They should be dynamic so people can get to the information behind the report, to make their own connections and draw their own conclusions.

All of which seems easy enough.

It's not.

Why isn't this easy and obvious?

Business intelligence is not a technology you just drop into place.

And most business intelligence solutions won't give you what you really need.

The problem is, every business intelligence vendor will tell you that they have exactly what you need.

This is not true.

They will tell you that everything needs to go through a centralized, proprietary semantic layer in order to protect and organize your data.

This is not true.

They will tell you that their solution is the easiest to use, easiest to maintain, most powerful, most all-inclusive, and the fastest system to deliver ROI.

This is not true.

Because no single company can deliver all of that for every situation.

The truth is, before you begin implementing a business intelligence solution, you must figure out what your people actually need. How they work. And what will actually work for them, so they'll use it.

Only then can you intelligently pick the business intelligence vendor that delivers the right amount of power for each person who will use it. Because not everybody needs the same access.

And of course you should choose the easiest and most affordable solution to deploy, expand, and maintain, since you'll do each fairly often.

That's the truth. Ask anyone who has done it.

Especially those who have done it wrong.

At the very least, what do you need?

Most business experts agree that in order to deliver useful information, a business intelligence solution must deliver accurate, relevant, and timely information in a simple and easily understood manner.

What you need:

1. Fundamental analysis tools so your analysts can do what they already do with spreadsheets (this is a prerequisite, like basic college English or math).
2. Insight into your corporation's performance that would be difficult or impossible with current tools (like traditional spreadsheets).
3. Analysis that goes beyond the surface, so people can get to the root of the problem, by looking behind the numbers.
4. Information delivered in context so that reasonably smart people can make more informed (also known as "better") decisions.
5. The ability to produce reports automatically so the information can reach people when they need it.

How you need it:

1. Easy enough to administer and design so the business unit responsible for the information can own the business intelligence solution (with a little help from your information technology department, and preferably without adding to their workload).
2. Easy enough to understand and use so that all the different types of people who need to use the solution can get the information they need to do their job better (without giving them more access or power than they need).

3. And easy enough so you don't have everyone killing time in training classes learning to use it.

Anything less will be a very expensive distraction.

What results can you expect?

That depends on what kind of results you need to achieve.

One Ivy League university saw a \$20 million increase in donations *just by speeding up their access to information*.

A British utility company creates monthly management reports that used to take a week, *in just 20 minutes*. With one person. Because now their analysts work on other things, they are uncovering information and profits they couldn't see before.

In one western state, the State Controller Division now delivers the consolidated financial statements from 130 agencies *with just 10 people*. They estimate the total savings in millions of dollars.

A major health provider reduced online report generation costs *by over 60 percent*.

One southern automobile association *saves hundreds of thousands of dollars* each year by not producing and mailing unnecessary membership cards.

The same company freed their analysts from tracking memberships to do more strategic work, such as comparing member concentrations with population densities in order to find the best locations for new offices.

An aircraft company *saves more than 200 man-hours per month* just by automating reports. Manufacturing and service reports that took hours to prepare are now created automatically every night, and appear in the appropriate managers' email every morning.

A global communications firm uses business intelligence tools to save employees three hours per week. Which has given each of these people the time to discover new ways of making and saving money they never had before.

An Australian leasing company reduced personnel costs and improved customer service by speeding up their invoice reconciliation process *by a factor of ten*.

There are hundreds of similar stories in just about every industry. The results you will see will depend on what you need to do.

And how committed you, your executive team, and your people are to seeing and delivering results.

How can you use business intelligence in your business?

Believe it or not, business intelligence can deliver results in virtually every aspect of your business.

Pick a category.

Financial analysts can save time creating financial statements while sales managers can actually see sales representative productivity.

Marketing can track marketing campaigns, customer service can follow customer service statistics, and HR can stay abreast of personnel and employment trends.

Facilities can see maintenance reports while manufacturing can track orders to build.

Did we miss anyone?

Oh. Even your "C-level" executives will know what's going on.

The secret here, is no big secret. To get intelligent information from the mountain of data you collect every day you need smart people asking smart questions.

Business intelligence automates the process of asking these questions and generating the reports that help formulate answers that guide business decisions.

So relevant, useful business information actually gets to people when they actually need it.

What will business intelligence help you do?

The right business intelligence system implemented properly will give your people the information they need, when they need it, in the form they need to see it, so they can act on it. But only once your analysts ask the right questions.

And the key to asking the right questions is not to be satisfied with obvious answers. Because the numbers often hide what's going on. For example, when twice the estimated sales at half the estimated cost result in a zero variance from the budget. Just

seeing the Actual, Budget, and Variance numbers won't tell you any of that.

For example:

Line Item	Actual	Budget	Variance
Widget Sales Expense	\$30,000	\$30,000	\$0
<u>Details</u>			
Number of Sales	100	50	50
Average Cost of Sale	\$300	\$600	(\$300)

What does that mean?

It could show you how your business mix has changed. Or that somebody may have sandbagged their numbers. Or that supply is nowhere close to demand.

Whatever it shows you, this is the kind of mission-critical information that leads to intelligent business decisions.

It also shows you how much you could lose by not seeing it.

What won't business intelligence help you do?

It won't automatically transform your organization into an opportunity-focused company.

You'll need to do that.

It won't automatically change the way you do business, interact with your customers, or deal with suppliers.

You'll need to do that.

It won't automatically deliver nuggets of useful information from a mountain of data.

You'll need smart people to do that.

Because your business analysts still need to find the data, remove any errors and inconsistencies, translate the data, perform calculations, and distribute the information the first time.

Then your business intelligence solution can pull together all the expertise from all of your analysts, automate the process, repeat it daily (or whenever), and make it widely available across your extended enterprise.

Which frees your analysts to find the hidden profitability, the new business opportunities,

the new ways to reduce costs that lie hidden in that mountain of data most companies call their data warehouse.

Translation: it frees them to do the jobs you hired them to do.

What do all these terms mean?

***ad hoc* query**

An unscheduled request that directs your database server to search through its data files for specific information or results.

Administration

The management of technology.

Administrator

Someone who manages technology.

Analyst

Someone who analyzes data, performs calculations, and distributes the information in the form of reports.

Automate

To take a process and replicate it using technology in order to perform it without requiring people.

Business Analytics

Another term for business intelligence.

Context

The background or reference information, such as a time frame, that gives useful data meaning.

Data

The raw numbers, which lack context, that drive business analytics.

Data Mart

A data collection and organization system designed to work on a departmental level.

Data Warehouse

A data collection and organization system designed to work on an enterprise level.

Database

The basic data organization system. There are two primary types: relational and multi-dimensional.

Decision support (aka DSS)

A term used in the early 90's to describe business analytics taken up the corporate ladder so that executives can base decisions on intelligent information about their business.

Design

How your analysts develop and create queries and reports.

Drill anywhere

The ability to look at a set of information, subordinate to an existing set, to discover potentially unknown relationships, as opposed to using a predefined set of relationships.

Drill down

The ability to look at the numbers behind the numbers to get more information or more context about what you are seeing.

Environment

The conditions surrounding your data, such as your databases, data formats, servers, network, and anything else that might affect it.

Functionality

What a product or service can do or offer.

Implementation

The process of installing and deploying a new product or service (such as business intelligence software).

Information

Useful data presented in relation to other useful data, so that it has meaning.

Infrastructure

How your information technology environment is organized.

Intuitive

Something that follows a natural logical progression, or works the way you do.

IT

Information Technology—the group responsible for managing most computer-related activities.

Maintenance

The ongoing process of keeping something running efficiently throughout its life.

Multi-dimensional database

A database that stores data in a series of summary tables allowing analysts to quickly access summarized information without searching through gigabytes of data.

Needs assessment

The formal consulting name for "asking what people want and need."

OLAP

Online Analytical Processing. The engine behind business intelligence software, which comes in two flavors: ROLAP (Relational OLAP for relational databases) and MOLAP (Multidimensional OLAP for multidimensional databases).

Parameters

The criteria and calculations you apply to the data to get more relevant information.

Real-time

What the rest of the world calls "live".

Relational database

A database that stores data in groups by type of information as they relate to other relative information, typically without presenting summarized data tables.

Relevant

Information that makes sense to the person receiving it so they can act on it.

Reports

How analysts wrap context around information to make it useful to more people.

ROI

Return On Investment. How long it takes improvements in revenue or cost savings that are directly related to your investment to exceed the total cost of that investment.

Seat license

The cost per person to license software for a set period of time.

Semantic Layer

A buffer that presents database tables in a form that business users understand.

Shelfware

Software that doesn't get used, so the only way you know you have it is because the manual is on the shelf.

SQL

Structured Query Language. A language used to communicate with databases.

Tangible results

Real numbers—like increased sales, reduced inventories, lower costs—that you can measure.

TCO

Total Cost of Ownership. How much it costs to own this product throughout its life.

User

Someone who uses technology. The rest of the world calls them "people".

Can anyone explain semantic layers in simple English?

A semantic layer is a buffer to protect your data from people who don't have a good technical understanding. Since about 80 percent of the people using business intelligence in any organization fit that description, you need some protection against accidents.

What you don't need is something to protect your data from your analysts. Something that slows or prevents them from getting to the underlying information they need. Which is what happens when the semantic layer gets too big and thick. When everything has to go through the semantic layer. And when you have to duplicate every data source you own as its own "universe" or "cube".

Because when you have to duplicate everything you own, you have a lot of redundancy.

And you don't have the flexibility and freedom to change your data sources quickly, easily, or even affordably. Because adding, changing, updating, or upgrading a data source means budgeting for someone to add a new semantic layer.

Think of the semantic layer as an automated IT person whose sole job is to repeat your question to the data warehouse (which has its own security and data protection already in place).

In some circles, they're called "paper pushers". In others, "bureaucrats".

In business intelligence they're known as the "universe" or "cube".

You can refer to most of them as unnecessary.

Why?

Because the thick semantic layers were designed to sit on top of transactional data—such as the unfiltered flow of credit-card transactions. This semantic layer then organizes your data in ways that are easier for business people. Which is exactly what a data warehouse, data mart, or reporting database *already does*.

Once data warehouses were introduced (15 years ago), a thick semantic layer was suddenly slow and unnecessary. It simply duplicated work done by the data warehouse.

Making it outdated technology.

So companies who built solutions using thick semantic layers repositioned it as important for data integrity.

It's not.

In fact, a thick semantic layer can actually introduce errors. Because *somebody* has to duplicate *all* of the information and references *every* time the data source changes in *any* way. Failure to do so immediately gives you inaccurate data.

Which leads to flawed decisions.

A more intelligent approach is to protect the data from your non-technical people (and vice-versa), while still allowing your analysts to drill deeper for the information they need.

Without getting in the way.

What do you need to know to make an intelligent decision about business intelligence?

Start by asking what the group that needs business intelligence actually needs, and you'll make a more intelligent decision than most.

Find out how they work, and find a solution that works their way, and you'll be way ahead of the game.

How?

Ask them. Watch them. Sit down with them and watch how they do their jobs. Take notes. Listen. Write down what you learn (consultants call this "needs assessment"-some even have forms).

Because if you can deliver a tool that they can use without a lot of training, they'll probably use it.

Overall, it pays to look for three things in a solution: smarter, faster, and cheaper.

Smarter.

How much does the system take advantage of what you already have in place? Does the system duplicate efforts (and costs) by adding a thick semantic layer? Does the semantic layer add unnecessary overhead to your network, slowing performance for everyone? You need this answer to calculate the next two.

Faster.

How long does it take from the moment you decide to the point where you start to get results from your system? The faster the better. (The answer can be less than one day in most cases).

Cheaper.

How much does it cost to buy, own, operate, maintain, and administer? The last three may sound redundant, but beware. Maintenance costs (updates and upgrades), administration costs (database and system administrators who work with your solution), and operations costs (like additional servers and network devices) may fall into different budget areas and get hidden. You need this answer before you can calculate your ROI.

If you ask the right questions of your people and your business intelligence vendors, you'll get the kind of answers that will deliver results.

And that seems like a pretty intelligent approach.

So how do you know what to ask?

Start by cutting through the B.S.

What do you need to know to cut through the sales and marketing B.S.?

Know yourself. Know what you need, what you want, and how you want it.

That's the fastest way.

Then ask your business intelligence suppliers what they have that meets your needs. Your budget, for instance.

You may not come out of this with an apples-to-apples supplier comparison. But you will get a very good idea of how much each solution actually costs based on what they can deliver. You may also get a lot of resistance, because now you're in charge.

And they've lost half of their sales tactics.

You'll see lots of ROI (return on investment) and TCO (total cost of ownership) whoop-de-do. Ask how they got them. Ask how those numbers look after one year. And after two changes to your data sources or infrastructure.

Ask what costs those ROI numbers *don't* include (the hidden costs that you will need to take into account).

Ask how long until you start seeing *results*. In most companies, results are what count. There are many cases of companies seeing results in less than a day.

Ask for references. Check them.

Talk to as many analysts as you can.

Beware of the FUD (Fear, Uncertainty, and Doubt) Factor. This is one of the favorite tactics of big players when their offerings don't match up well (smaller vendors rarely use this tactic, since they can't rely on their size and strength to create concern about a competitor's longevity). They want you to be afraid that if you don't choose the biggest and most expensive, you will fail. This is as false in business intelligence as it is in automobiles.

Make sure the vendor you choose can *honestly* deliver what you need, how you need it, and when you need it. Make them run their demo on *your* live data. Look beyond the flashy features and see what the solution is providing. See how long it takes them to show you meaningful results from your data.

Does it give you relevant information you can use now? Or abstract data that could become useful if you knew what to do with it (and had the time to do it)?

Is it easy to see things your business is doing that you couldn't see before?

What nobody will tell you about buying business intelligence.

- 1.** How well it works depends on what you know before you decide. Which means you need to do the research up front (or get somebody to do it) so that you understand what you need your business intelligence system to deliver (like the results that will determine if your deployment is a success or failure).
- 2.** Make sure that you don't mistake unique technology and flashy graphics for delivering fundamental business analysis. They don't always go together.
- 3.** Don't be satisfied with just the obvious stuff. Make sure your business intelligence solution can dig deeper, and give you the information you need to get to what is important. Get the vendor to run their solution on your data to see what comes up.
- 4.** Be certain that the people who need to do something with the information in any report can quickly and easily get the information they need from that report. If the information is abstract, it has little value. You need information presented in context, or you're wasting people's time.
- 5.** If you can't manage your business intelligence solution from within your business group, then it probably can't keep up with the pace of your business. Have the people who own the information also own the budget and the administration. This means you better make sure your solution is easy to design, administer, and maintain.
- 6.** Your IT department really doesn't need—or want—to add more overhead. They don't want to add more overhead to the network, and they don't want to add more overhead to manage your business intelligence system. Just like anybody else, they want to keep their lives simple and straightforward, while they protect the integrity of the data. Look for something that is easy to install, easy to own, easy to maintain.
- 7.** Your people will only change their approach if it is easier, faster, or will make them more money. So your business intelligence system better be pretty easy to use for the different types of people using it. Otherwise it will become very expensive shelfware. Which rarely delivers any kind of ROI. Since most of your people shouldn't need any training to use it, ask your references how much training they actually needed.
- 8.** A lack of technology will not prevent you from getting results from your business intelligence solution. Getting your people to use the technology appropriately will. Make sure your solution is easy and intuitive, so your people will actually use it to deliver tangible business results that give you a real strategic advantage.
- 9.** You will change your business by changing the way your people work and think about their work, not by simply deploying some new business intelligence software.

What do you need to include in your budget?

First plan for everything you can think of. Then think of more.

The obvious first thing is the purchase cost.

You will pay for seat licenses for everybody who will use any piece of the solution. Be careful not to overbuy here. Match the needs of each person with the most appropriate tool (80 percent of the people using your system need only view reports where they can change a few parameters—this is generally the least expensive component of the software).

Realistically, you don't want everybody performing *ad hoc* queries all day long. It will overwhelm your servers and your network (adding a whole new expense to your budget). Too much functionality can be as big a mistake as not enough. It adds complexity. And complexity leads to headaches.

Headaches you might pay extra to enjoy.

Next, budget for implementation costs. Fast talkers will gloss over the many big hidden implementation costs. Use caution here. Don't pay for things you don't need. Don't pay for systems that replicate your entire environment, because then you'll pay to have someone recreate the redundant system every time you upgrade, change, or add data sources. Compounding the amount of double work and costs.

Then there are training costs for all of those people (depending on the solution you choose). No matter what you choose, plan for some kind of training. Even if it's training you develop and deploy yourself.

Finally there are maintenance costs. This is the part most vendors leave out of their ROI discussions. Which is criminal, since it typically runs between one-third and one-half of your total cost. And you'll pay that much every year.

Just accept that new data sources will be added on a regular basis. Then accept that your IT staff will need to modify the metadata (at least) to accommodate the new information supply. And budget for these maintenance costs.

These are just the obvious costs associated with a typical business intelligence solution. But there are other costs that tend to remain hidden until after the contract is signed.

What are your hidden costs?

Like any enterprise solution, the business intelligence sales process is prone to hiding certain costs in order to prove a stronger ROI or TCO story.

So here are some of those hidden costs that you might want to include in your budget.

Your training costs include more than just the price of training. You need to budget for the lost productivity while people are being trained.

Your implementation costs will grow if you go with a system based on complex semantic layers. These cumbersome layers not only add extra implementation and maintenance costs, they also add network overhead. The costs (from your own IT department as well as from consultants) could escalate faster than professional baseball salaries as your implementation team struggles to create complex semantic layers for each data source.

And they'll escalate again each time you upgrade, update, or change any underlying data sources, servers, or even software. Some vendors even require you (or your IT department) to take the old system offline to upgrade the software (which is never a good idea).

All of these hidden costs can add up to one-third or more of your budget. Make sure you ask for these costs, plan for them, and get them covered in the contract.

Basically, make sure they don't stay hidden until it's too late.

In English, what are the main differences between the various business intelligence solutions?

Each business intelligence solution has its own strengths and weaknesses. Some are better for certain environments and organizations than others. You have to find the one that best matches your needs.

Brio Software™

Brio Software offers a full line of business intelligence products and services that are considered the easiest to use and administer. Designed for data warehouse environ-

ments that change often, Brio products are quick to install, implement, and upgrade, allowing people to begin analyzing their business immediately, with little or no training.

Brio is best suited for organizations where a business unit will be responsible for maintenance, since it takes advantage of the security and functionality built into the data sources. It is not ideal for companies needing extremely sophisticated statistical analysis or integrated data mining capabilities.

Business Objects®

Business Objects offers a full line of business intelligence products designed for companies with relatively static data environments or transactional data environments without a data warehouse. To compensate for their assumption that you lack a data warehouse, Business Objects introduces a complex buffer—the "Universe"—between your people and your data sources.

However, the "Universe" is required to get full functionality from a Business Objects solution, even if you already have a data warehouse. Which places a heavier administrative demand on IT groups. However, it does give IT departments slightly tighter control over their data.

Cognos®

Cognos offers the widest array of business intelligence products, from ETL to advanced visualization. Many of these products are currently being integrated with each other.

Like Business Objects, Cognos is best suited to static data environments or transactional data environments without a data warehouse for very similar reasons. Your implementation and maintenance teams must build and maintain a "Cognos Cube" around each data source to buffer the data from your people.

Crystal Decisions™

Crystal Decisions delivers good static reporting functionality with Crystal Reports, however its business intelligence capabilities lack the power of other solutions.

This makes Crystal Decisions a good fit for companies with limited analysis needs, but more widespread reporting needs.

MicroStrategy®

MicroStrategy offers products designed to retrieve data from detailed relational databases, rather than multidimensional databases that include summarized data. This makes it best suited for retailers and other companies with massive amounts data and lots of customers.

Because the business intelligence engine must search through very large (multi-giga-byte or terabyte) databases to return results, performance suffers. To compensate, MicroStrategy offers "intelligent cubes" to provide multidimensional capabilities.

How can you avoid the biggest mistakes people make with business intelligence?

Ask the right questions. And gather your business requirements. Never narrow the range of solutions before you know what you're trying to solve.

Make sure you start with a project plan. Skipping the plan is like trying to sail to Hawaii without a compass. It's possible, but it's unlikely you'll get where you want to go. Put the project plan in writing.

Set a realistic schedule with realistic expectations. Then manage both. Don't let anyone make either unrealistic or impossible. By the same token, once you set the project scope, do not expand it. Achieve what you set out to do. Then you can add to it once it's up and running.

Plan to measure success and promote the results. This means you need to know what you're going to measure before you begin (in other words, plan for the big picture, that's what you'll be graded on).

Make sure your team has the appropriate mix of business and technical skills. Also make sure you will have continuity in key positions.

Don't limit leadership to those with titles. Confusing titles with roles and responsibilities on a team can be disastrous. Sometimes the people in power don't know what the people doing the work need to know. Encourage discussion. Don't squelch disagreement.

Don't believe technology will solve everything or that any performance issues can be solved by IT alone. Stay focused on getting results, not on acronyms like ROI, TCO, or even SQL. You're not after technology. You're after results.

And never design for the ease of the developers at the expense of the people who will use it.

Whatever you do, don't let anyone sell you a "one-size-fits-all" solution. Don't take any consultant's recommendations without question. Be careful what you outsource. Check references carefully. Ask hard questions, like "What went wrong?" and "What would you buy next time around?"

Choose the right sponsor in your organization. This is the person or group with the most to gain—and lose—from getting your business intelligence solution up and running. Don't let your IT department alone drive the project. The business unit needing the results should drive it. Build a partnership between your business unit and your IT department.

Know the difference between program and project management. Pay attention to management and operational issues. Failure to do so may result in severe neck pains.

Realize that the real challenges might lie in acquiring the right source data. Set appropriate expectations about the quality of your data. Plan to have somebody clean it up. You will need lots of detailed historical data. This will not be "clean."

Maintain the authority to select the software. *This is important.* Don't play politics. You need to choose the vendor and solution that will get you the results you need.

What is the cost of making a mistake?

The wrong business intelligence solution could be very expensive if you don't monitor results before, during, and after implementation. Not just ROI, but results. Are you getting the information you need? Are people using it? Is the information accurate, timely, and relevant?

When you stay focused on getting results, you can spot a mistake quickly, minimize the effect, and get on the right path before good money follows bad.

Business intelligence is not cheap.

You're not going to find funding for this in petty cash. There is a software (and possibly hardware) cost, an implementation cost, and a maintenance cost. All three require both time and money.

Don't discount any of them.

It can give you misleading results.

Anytime you are not dealing with a version of, and not the actual data, you have the potential for errors. This is especially true when your business intelligence solution requires that you replicate data sources into a proprietary system such as a "Universe" or "cube".

Another source for misleading results is only getting a partial picture where you can't "drill down" to get more information. While the information you see is precise, it won't show what's behind those numbers, and then you don't get an accurate picture of what is going on.

This can lead to very unfortunate—and expensive—decisions.

It can take people away from what they need to do.

When people are out of the office for a day of training, their work doesn't get done. When they're out of the office for a day of training on a solution that doesn't give you the results you need, that lost day never gets recouped.

Now multiply this by all the people who will need to be trained (especially if the solution isn't completely intuitive) to see what you're really in for.

It can be expensive to maintain.

If it's not easy to upgrade, update, and evolve, a business intelligence solution can cost many times more in maintenance and consulting fees than you originally paid for it. If, every time you update or add a database, you have to recreate the entire semantic layer, this will not be your most cost-effective solution.

Your business intelligence solution needs to change and grow as you do—that means quickly, easily, and affordably.

Don't be fooled by initial ROI calculations.

Especially those done by "one-size-fits-all" calculators that seem too good to be true. The numbers probably are. Look at who is going to use your business intelligence solution to do what. What will deliver the information they need to do their jobs with minimal interruption, training, and maintenance?

Why should you do this now?

Sports teams introduce new plays when they have time to learn them without the pressures of the game. They know this is the most effective way to gain competitive advantage.

The same holds true for you.

Which makes a downturn in the economy the perfect time to put a new system in place.

Before you get too busy to do it right.

Right now, you have the time and opportunity to discover what you need to deliver and how to deliver it. It's also the right time to get your people comfortable with a new way of doing business.

Comfort is the key.

If they're not comfortable, they won't use it when the pressure picks up.

That's why smart companies roll out new strategies during slower cycles.

It's a smarter way of playing the game.

Except this isn't a game.

Compliments of Brio Software.

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